



SAFETY TOOLBOX TALK

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Topic:			Health risks from the sun		

This briefing is not intended to tell you how to do your jobs, it is designed to help keep you safe. We want everybody to be able to return home safely to their family and friends at the end of each day.

A sunny day makes most of us feel good, but too much strong sunlight can be damaging to the skin. The problem is caused by the ultraviolet - UV - rays in strong sunlight. People who are outdoors for a long time may get more sun on their skin than is healthy for them, and should note the following:

We all know that sunburn can blister your skin and make it peel. In summer, even on cloudy days, enough UV can filter through to cause burning. The most serious effect is an increased chance of skin cancer later in life. It is almost always easy to cure but it should be caught early. Too much sun will also speed up the ageing of your skin, making it leathery, mottled and wrinkled.

Some medicines and contact with some chemicals used at work (such as dyes, wood preservatives, coal-tar and pitch products), can make your skin more sensitive to sunlight.

Who is at risk of skin cancer?

People with white skin are at most risk. Take particular care if you have:

- fair or freckled skin that does not tan, or burns before it tans;
- red or fair hair and light-coloured eyes;
- a large number of moles - over 100 in young people, or over 50 in older people.

Do not get burned.

Get to know how your skin reacts to sunlight. This will help you decide what precautions to take. Getting burned now may increase your chances of skin cancer many years later. Try to avoid the reddening that is the first sign of burning. The best protection is to shade your skin from the direct sunlight. A suntan may give some protection against burning but does not eliminate the long-term cancer risk; nor will it protect against premature ageing.

Sunscreens

Sunscreen creams and lotions can add useful protection for parts of your body that are not easy to shade from the sun. Look for a sun protection factor (SPF) rating of 10 or more.

Check your skin.

The first warning sign is often a small scabby spot which does not clear after a few weeks. Look for changed or newly formed moles or any skin discoloration. It is normal for moles to grow until you are about 18 years old, but as an adult you should show your doctor any moles which grow or change. If you notice any of these signs consult your own doctor. Fortunately, most of these signs will be harmless, but medical checks may be needed to be sure. Even if a spot is cancerous, simple modern treatments can usually cure it and most do not spread to other parts of the body. The smaller the spot the easier it is to cure. So do not put off going to the doctor when you know you should.

If you have any kind of medical check-up tell the doctor that you have an outdoor job and ask if there are any suspicious signs on your skin.



Discussion Points

Do you know how to get hold of sun cream?